SACRED SEASONS · ADVENT 2026

Week 1: Hope While We Wait

November 29 to December 5 · Spiritual practices for small groups and personal prayer

This week's prayer

God, let me stay awake to you while I wait, and let my longing be seen.

HOW TO USE THESE PRACTICES

- This week has four passages for Lectio Divina (pray one each day or choose one for a gathering) and two practices to lead with a small group or pray on your own. Each takes 10 to 20 minutes.
- If you are leading a group, read the steps aloud slowly. Let the silences be long enough to feel a little long.
- Offer the questions as invitations. No one has to answer out loud, and there are no wrong answers.
- Every practice is also in the free Sacred Seasons app, where you can read it or listen as Dr. Julene guides you: sacredseasons.julenetegerstrand.com

BEFORE YOU LEAD

Before you invite others to keep watch, notice how tired you are. What are you waiting for this Advent that has nothing to do with how well your programs go?

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Written by Julene Tegerstrand. She developed these practices over many drafts, working with Claude (Anthropic's AI assistant) on wording and layout, and then edited them herself in several passes. The final text is hers, reviewed and approved by the author.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Isaiah 64:7-9

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether people share their words and thoughts aloud or do so in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

These verses come near the end of a long prayer. The people have lost their temple and feel that God has hidden from them. They say so. And then, in the middle of their grief, they proclaim a transitional word: "Yet."

> 7 *No one calls on Your name or strives to take hold of You. For You have hidden*
> *Your face from us and delivered us into the hand of our iniquity.*
> 8 *But now, O LORD, You are our Father; we are the clay, and You are the potter; we*
> *are all the work of Your hand.*
> 9 *Do not be angry, O LORD, beyond measure; do not remember our iniquity forever.*
> *Oh, look upon us, we pray; we are all Your people!*
>
> Isaiah 64:7-9 (BSB)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. Why might it be catching you today? What does it touch in your life right now? You might notice the word "Yet," and how it sits with you. *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God about it? Speak in a way one friend talks to another. You pretend you are holding the clay in your hands and tell the potter what you hope for, or what you're afraid of.

Fourth reading. Now rest. You are clay in the hands of someone who made you and keeps you. Maybe all God wants from this prayer is to give you rest.

Carry with you: *"Yet, O Lord, you are our Father; we are the clay."*

Try this: Today, when you notice yourself hurrying or worrying, say the word "Yet" and remember who holds you. This isn't a way to ignore your hurrying or worrying. Bring the memory of who holds you to your feelings and thoughts.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Psalm 80:17-19

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether people share their words and thoughts aloud or do so in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Psalm 80 is a whole community's prayer after their lives have fallen apart. Its refrain happens three times, and each time the name of God gets a little longer. Here we hear the psalm's last promise and its last refrain.

> 17 *Let Your hand be upon the man at Your right hand, on the son of man You have raised up for Yourself.*
> 18 *Then we will not turn away from You; revive us, and we will call on Your name.*
> 19 *Restore us, O LORD God of Hosts; cause Your face to shine upon us, that we may be saved.*
>
> Psalm 80:17-19 (BSB)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What in you, or in your people, needs restoring? Where do you long to see God's face shine? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God about it? You might ask to be given life again. You might name the people you are praying with, the "us" of this psalm.

Fourth reading. Now rest. Let God's face shine on you. The restoring is God's work.

Carry with you: *"Restore us, O Lord God of hosts; let your face shine."*

Try this: Today, when you see someone's face, a neighbor, a stranger, someone in the news, pray quietly, "Let your face shine."

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

1 Corinthians 1:7-9

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether people share their words and thoughts aloud or do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Paul is writing to a church that frustrated him. They were divided and struggling. He begins by thanking them anyway, and he tells them that while they wait, they already have what they need.

> 7 *Therefore you do not lack any spiritual gift as you eagerly await the revelation of our Lord Jesus Christ.*
>
> 8 *He will sustain you to the end, so that you will be blameless on the day of our Lord Jesus Christ.*
>
> 9 *God, who has called you into fellowship with His Son Jesus Christ our Lord, is faithful.*
>
> 1 Corinthians 1:7-9 (BSB)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What gift have you already been given for this season of waiting? Who has God given you as partners along the way? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might give thanks. You might tell God where you feel you are lacking. You might rest in the words "God is faithful."

Fourth reading. Now rest in God's faithfulness. God will strengthen you to the end.

Carry with you: *"God is faithful, by whom you were called into the partnership of his Son."*

Try this: Today, name one gift you see in someone else, especially someone who frustrates you, and thank God for it.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Mark 13:34-37

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether people share their words and thoughts aloud or do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Jesus tells a short story about a household waiting for its master to come home. He names the four watches of the night: evening, midnight, cockcrow, and dawn.

> 34 *It is like a man going on a journey who left his house, put each servant in charge of his own task, and instructed the doorkeeper to keep watch.*
>
> 35 *Therefore keep watch, because you do not know when the master of the house will return—whether in the evening, at midnight, when the rooster crows, or in the morning.*
>
> 36 *Otherwise, he may arrive without notice and find you sleeping.*
>
> 37 *And what I say to you, I say to everyone: Keep watch!"*
>
> Mark 13:34-37 (BSB)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. You don't need to know why it catches you. Just notice it.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. Which watch of the night are you living in right now? What would it mean to be awake to God there? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might tell God how tired you are. You might ask to be awake to God's coming. The watch Jesus asks for is attention, and attention can be restful.

Fourth reading. Now rest. Jesus keeps watch with you, and you are watched over.

Carry with you: *"And what I say to you I say to all: Keep awake."*

Try this: Tonight, before you sleep, ask one question: Where was God with me today, and did I notice?

A PRACTICE FOR A SMALL GROUP

Restore Us: A Breath Prayer

Personal or group · 5 minutes



Psalm 80 is a whole community's prayer after things fell apart. Its refrain comes back three times, and each time the name of God gets a little fuller: "O God," then "O God of hosts," then "O Lord God of hosts." The need hasn't changed, and still the name of God keeps getting fuller.

Christians in many times and places have prayed a short line over and over, with the breath, with beads, or in song. Repeating the same words lets them sink below the thinking mind into the heart.

> [3] *Restore us, O God, and cause Your face to shine upon us, that we may be saved.*
> [7] *Restore us, O God of Hosts, and cause Your face to shine upon us, that we may be saved.*
> [19] *Restore us, O LORD God of Hosts; cause Your face to shine upon us, that we may be saved.*
>
> Psalm 80:3, 7, 19 (BSB)

STEPS

1. Let your breathing slow down on its own. You don't need to control it.
2. As you breathe in, pray silently, "Restore us, O God."
3. As you breathe out, pray, "let your face shine."
4. Let's pray it together three times, slowly. Breathe in… "Restore us, O God." Breathe out… "let your face shine." Breathe in… "Restore us, O God." Breathe out… "let your face shine." Breathe in… "Restore us, O God." Breathe out… "let your face shine."
5. Keep going for about five minutes. When your mind wanders, and it will, come back to the words without scolding yourself. The point is to rest in God.
6. Finish by sitting quietly for one more minute.

QUESTIONS TO PRAY WITH OR SHARE

- What in me, or in us, needs restoring?
- Whose face do I long to see shine with God's shining face?
- Did anything shift in me as I kept repeating the words?
- Who is the "us" I found myself praying for?

IF YOU'RE TIRED

Pray one breath of it at a red light, on the bus, or in line at the store.

WITH A GROUP, HOUSEHOLD, OR CHILDREN

Say or sing the refrain together at the start and end of a meeting. A leader can sing the first half, and everyone answers with the second, the way many congregations around the world pray the psalms.

> **A word of care.** For some people, paying attention to the breath raises anxiety. If that's you, let the words ride on your footsteps as you walk, or hold something small in your hand and pray the line each time you press it.

A PRACTICE FOR A SMALL GROUP

Gifts While Waiting

Personal or group · 10 minutes

Paul wrote to a church that frustrated him. They had divisions, rivalries, and plenty of problems he would name later in the letter. Yet he begins with gratitude: "I give thanks to my God always for you."

Notice that Paul's "you" is plural. The gifts belong to the community, and they were given for each other.

> 3 *Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.*
> 4 *I always thank my God for you because of the grace He has given you in Christ Jesus.*
> 5 *For in Him you have been enriched in every way, in all speech and all knowledge,*
> 6 *because our testimony about Christ was confirmed in you.*
> 7 *Therefore you do not lack any spiritual gift as you eagerly await the revelation of our Lord Jesus Christ.*
> 8 *He will sustain you to the end, so that you will be blameless on the day of our Lord Jesus Christ.*
> 9 *God, who has called you into fellowship with His Son Jesus Christ our Lord, is faithful.*
>
> 1 Corinthians 1:3-9 (BSB)

STEPS

1. Read verses 3 through 9 slowly.
2. Before you ask God for anything today, write down three gifts you have been given. Consider these as spoken gratitudes. They can come from your own life, your household, your church, or your people.
3. Add one gift you see in someone who frustrates you. Paul's Corinthians were frustrating too.
4. Thank God for each gift by name.
5. Now bring your requests to God, whatever they are.

QUESTIONS TO PRAY WITH OR SHARE

- Which gift surprised me when I wrote it down?
- What gift have I received from people whose culture or story is different from mine?
- What happens in me when I thank God for someone who frustrates me?
- What gift might God be asking me to share in the midst of a season of waiting?

IF YOU'RE TIRED

Name one gift in one sentence.

WITH A GROUP, HOUSEHOLD, OR CHILDREN

You can adapt this practice for a group. Or you can begin a meeting with each person naming one gift they see in the congregation, the small group, or neighborhood. You might even do this responsively where a person names a gift, and all respond with verse 4.

> **A word of care.** If gratitude feels forced right now, that's okay. Being thankful doesn't erase what's hard, and nobody should be told to be grateful for their suffering. Paul gave thanks and then named real problems.

Sacred Seasons

A free Advent prayer app from spiritual director Rev. Dr. Julene Tegerstrand. One prayer each day from November 29 to Christmas Eve, to read or to hear. No ads, no account. You can sign up or find out more at sacredseasons.julenetegerstrand.com

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